

Mzungu! Transcript

Conversations from Walk F.

EP

Would you normally be in the office today?

Participant

Yes, yeah so it's really good to get some fresh air instead

EP

Do you do things like this with your groups very often?

Participant

Walks. Not really. We're starting to put together timetable so we'll get them out throughout the summer to Autumn

EP

What kind of groups do you have going on at the moment?

Participant

So we have exercise groups, but they're doing as of now Zumba

EP

Alright, yeah.

Participant

When the weather is, you know nicer, they do it in the park. And then we have cooking group, a sewing club, now have English classes, have a baby and mother group, and we have a different youth groups, for different age groups.

EP

That's nice.

Participant

So we have the girls, the strong black girls from Black Girls group on Wednesdays, and then we have the 12-15 year olds on Thursday and 16+ on Friday

EP

Wow. So you really cover all ages, then

Participant

Yes, yeah it's always busy

EP

I can imagine it's like a lot of connection building and community building there. A lot of people making friends at the the groups

Participant

Yes, yes absolutely especially the mothers and babies group as some of the ladies, you know, they came here, they don't have any family. They might have their husband, but he's at work. and feel they feel a bit isolated I don't speak the language. I don't know anyone, so they come to the group, they start building relationships with the other mothers. So they even do play dates outside, you know, by themselves we do lots of picnics throughout the summer. At least, like twice a week. We do picnics, for the mothers and the children. It's nice.

EP

Must be amazing to see like the impact that they have on these women's lives.

Participants

Ohh, that one's interested [cow licking Andy's hand]

EP

What kind of areas are like the women that you worked with like originally from?
[exclamation at friendly cows]

Participant

And this European, but mostly from African countries or South Africa, Zimbabwe and Portuguese, Ex Portuguese colonies like Santome, Camp Verde

EP

Are the English classes like well attended?

Participant

Yes, we have three classes per week. So on Monday, Mondays is for for people that need childcare so mothers have young children that don't attend, you know nursery. Or reception so they can attend the class and we have support workers looking after the children. Tuesdays for beginners. Thursdays for intermediate learners.

EP

OK.

Participant

And they are doing ICT classes and all learning you know how to turn on computer how to write an e-mail, how to draft CV how to how to use word, excel.

EP

Oh, OK, yeah. Yeah, it's so important, isn't it? Everything has turned online so to have those skills.

—

Next clip

EL:

What I love about these walks, is that they're a real, they're such different sections to them they'll be the wooded areas and the bits along the river where you get the

different sounds then suddenly you're in the open where there's this wide vista of amazing beauty

Participant
I love the wooded areas

EL
Yeah me too I suppose it's what you're familiar with from growing up and I grew up near lots of woodlands so I find them really comforting.

Participant
'I grew up in the countryside as well, and cows and just fields and things so that's good

EL
' Yeah It's calming isn't it'

Participant
It's calming, I think whether you grew up in it or not it's calming, really nice, the thing is it's free and accessible

EL
Yes, yeah and it should stay that way

Participant
Yeah

EL
I was reading about people who follow ancient footpaths and they like visiting really ancient trees that are you know hundreds of years old and are marked off and one man was following one or trying to find one of these trees that's really famous and he found that the footpath that had been a public footpath had just been taken off all the maps it's on land that just been bought by someone who was against it and had done something I don't know money changed hands or whatever whatever you do to get a public footpath taken off it's just so wrong on loads of levels this poor unvisited tree and the man trespassed to go and find it to I just really want to go see this tree and walking along this really ancient footpath where the ground has been worn down by just hundreds of years of people walking on it and no one's walking on it anymore cos it's just been

Participant
I hope they don't do stuff like this here

EL
Yeah I know so we've all got to be sort of we just gotta keep using them and be really vigilant because you just don't know things could change that's a bit of a sinister way of looking at things but I think yeah we do have to continue to use these because they're a real treasure all the footpaths

Participant

The thing for me is something about the Suffolk countryside because it's really, really.. being a foreigner from outside you know having visited other parts I think Suffolk is different quite different Which way?

EL

We're going to go that way I think let me just double check with my betters my sense of direction has gone down since having children along with everything else
So you said you think Suffolk's different?

Participant

Yes I just love the countryside it's just absolutely lovely as a social worker I've travelled alot around Suffolk and I did a lot of craft fairs around Suffolk and you tend to do craft fairs around the nicer parts of Suffolk and so you can really appreciate the landscape and the cottages you know the country life so it's really enjoyable

Next clip

EP

So are you thinking about organising more walks in the future?

Participant

Um how we got into this one is because Jenny and her colleague are organising some walks with us, supporting us

EP

So you get the guides, like the experts...

Participant,

Yes, yes, of Suffolk

EP

..to show you the landscapes, as you were saying it's a lot easier to sort of like follow their lead and sort of...

Participant

Well we have to sort of make the most of things so we're taking this as part of our own wellbeing, looking after ourselves a bit

EP

Yeah you don't want to be stuck behind a screen in your office all day so it's nice to get out yeah

Walking definitely improves my wellbeing

Participant

Mine as well, same with me

EP

Do you go for walks like around where you live?

Participant

Just near where I live two minutes away, just walk around a field as long it's quiet in the field then I come back

EP

Like the birdsong [in the background]

Participant

It's all you need, it's cheap and it's free, but it's just I'm in control, I don't I can't do gym, I like Zumba or yoga you know...

EP

Getting your endorphins going

Participant

...Walking is the best

EP

Could you just say a little bit about the strong black women project you are running?

Participant

Strong Black Girls

EP

Black Girls - so is it for teenagers?

Participant

Yeah, teenagers, young girls, primary school as well. It's just a youth project for the girls, they get to learn self-esteem and do arts and crafts.

EP

What sort of arts and crafts?

Participant

At the moment they colour, they've actually got some interesting crafts coming up this summer, colouring, crafting, you know making masks

EP

I find crafting really good for my wellbeing as well a bit of escapism (audio unclear) as long as you can go back to reality

Participant

[laughs] must return eventually

EP

How long have you worked for PHOEBE?

Participant

Um 14 years I founded the organisation

EP

Oh wow amazing!

How big is your team now?

Participant

This is it mostly, except for sessional workers

EP

Like counsellors and people like that?

Participant

Yeah

EP

How many people was it when you first founded?

Participant

Just me and some students

EP

Oh really?

Participant

Yes

EP

So it's come a long way then, it's grown so much

Have the volunteers helped with the groups you were mentioning like the exercise classes and arts and crafts?

Participant

Yes they do, it's been helpful having that

EP

Yeah it just increases capacity doesn't it

Participant

It increases capacity and increases our ability to reach out and do things

EP

Yeah, is it the whole of Suffolk you support?

Participant

Yes

EP

That's quite a lot of people then

Participant

Laughs

EP

Would you ever branch out into other parts like Essex?

Participant

We have a group in Essex already [laughs]

EP

Oh wow!

Participant

We don't turn anyone away, it's just about you know what you said capacity

EP

Is there any other future plans for PHOEBE other than the walking?

Participant

Till Autumn we're booked up, different groups walking

EP

It's going to be a busy...

Participant

Summer

EP

Summer yeah [laughs]

So is it just one you've done so far and that was with Jenny?

Participant

No this is our first one

EP

Honoured that you started with us!

Next clip

EL

I want to know more about the T-shirts are they new or have you had them designed recently?

Participant

Oh we had them designed years ago, yeah during lockdown

EL

During lockdown?

Participant

Yeah during lockdown, lots of ideas came up in lockdown

EL

Who designed the logo?

Participant

We have a Zimbabwean designer we just told him what the name was and then he designed it

EL

And he got it right first time or did you go back like Constable 'no, no I want this'?

Participant

No he always says I'm sick and tired make up your mind, it's always back and forward but he's really good usually and yeah so the girls were spending time together

Participant 2

Oh it was the Whatsapp group

Participant

8 year old girls quite a lot of them

Participant 2

8 year old girls group came up with it

EL

They came up with the slogan?

Participant

Yeah the name, they were talking it was lockdown we were trying to just get them on Whatsapp and then

Participant 2

I had forgotten this we used to have a regular Zoom to empower them to get them to chat and connect and do activities

Participant

Online and on Whatsapp

Participant 2

And they said they want Strong Black Girls we then we started looking for designs for logos and things

Participant

And they were 8 at the time

Next clip

Jumping over the boggy field!

Next clip

EL

Do you know this area well?

Participant 2

No it is my first time

EL

Oh really oh great

Participant

I came from Africa to visit my daughter and she's a member of this

EL

Oh wow when did you come recently?

Participant 2

Yeah I came two months ago and I am going back home 8 months and I will come every year from now

EL

Oh great

Participant 2

In our area we don't use the properties like this the land in Africa

EL

Really?

Participant 2

Yeah we don't keep up

EL

Like system of footpaths and accessible

Participant 2

No organisation in those areas so the areas are not protected like this it needs a lot of

EL

Do you think it would ever be

Participant 2

It could be next year depend on what we did, do something later

EL

I was just saying to another member of the group that the oh they're taking pictures

I was just saying a few minutes that the public footpaths in this country are not always sometimes they can just be taken away or a landowner who pays the land the footpath crosses particularly problematic its up to people to carry on using them

and not making it sort of easy for them to be taken away even when they've exited for centuries it's not certain they start that way

Participant 2

You don't do that before when you see them like this.. Very grateful on what you did on the land, we're exploring the legend

EL

But it's wonderful that one of the legacies that Constable had was to make this landscape extra special I think apart from his artistic legacy that he would have been happy with that too

Participant 2

I like the flowers and the picture and I mostly drawing and things but now I am retired and staying home and not working at my age

EL

You were a what a teacher of young children?

Participant 2

Young and grown-ups like grade 9-10 from grade 1 up to grade 10 and I have taught for 37 years

EL

Oh wow that's a massive achievement It's a difficult thing to teach

Participant 2

And children and work, I have 4 children, I came here for the third one, third one is living here now

EL

And you're other four children are in Ethiopia?

Participant 2

One in America, a boy living in America, there's one in Versailles, one studied in France

EL

There's a real problem in this country in schools in getting art teachers in primary school

Participant 2

Actually I was not trained as an art teacher

EL

But you loved it?

Participant 2

Yeah by nature you gave you the classes and I have taught from grade 8+

EL

And you did you do lots of drawings or art activities outside?

Participant 2

Simply what I get for instance I draw this area by sitting free-hand only

EL

Out in the open or inside, out in the open like what Constable used to do

Participant 2

By nature, I don't have training only 10 days

Next clip

EP

What do you do then?

Participant

Yeah, I work for admin accounts

EP

Oh okay yeah. How long? How long have you been doing that for?

Participant

Recently, I've joined this month

EP

Oh wow, so really new then how are you finding it so far?

Participant

Good learning new things

EP

Yeah seems like quite a varied role then, seeing as you're on a walk right now. What were you doing before?

Participant

In Ipswich this is first job, before volunteering I have done for ICM. In India, I was working in bank.

EP

All right. So yeah, quite a different different role then. What made you settle in Ipswich?

Participant

My husband got a job here he works for BT so that's the reason we moved.

EP

Alright, yes there's a big base here isn't here. How are you finding? How long has it been now?

Participant
One year

EP
One, yeah, and how have you been finding it?

Participant
Good. Yeah. Cool place. Silent place. Not very busy, it's nice. I've been in cities. Busy cities, so it's like cool, good place.

EP
Different change of pace.

Participant
What do you do?

EP
So I work for Cambridge Libraries at the moment, but I used to work for a charity in Ipswich before that. And yeah, I still live in Ipswich

Participant
What charity?

EP
So it was called SRC it supported women and girls who had experienced violence. So it was a pretty heavy, heavy role. So yeah, I feel like like the library's giving me like a nice break from it, but there's definitely parts of the role that I miss

Participant
What is now like this project?

EP
So this is the Constable project which is with the Fitzwilliam Museum in Cambridge, Cambridge Digital Humanities as well and and we just wanted to the project members just wanted to find a way to like bring the prints out from the galleries into the spaces in which they were created. So John Constable grew up in these parts of Suffolk and he painted here, so it's like ways of bringing it back to where it originated. And like finding new ways to explore it as well. So like. Yeah, sometimes galleries can be a bit inaccessible or not the best places to view art, so sometimes it's nice to just bring them out of the space and experience them amongst nature.

Participant
It's a beautiful place Cambridge, once we visited

EP
Oh did you yeah it is isn't it

Participant

Lots of universities, that's the place highest I walked, you know, 25,000 [steps] in one day

EP

Oh, wow.

Participant

Walking, walking walking, seeing all the universities

EP

Yeah. Yeah, it's definitely a place where everything is so far away. So like, you do end up doing a lot of walking.

Participant

Yeah.

EP

Well, what I like about Cambridge is they've got like the green spaces amongst the buildings. So it's like, I don't know about you, but like every green space in Cambridge has a cow. You know, it's like I'll just be walking to like a shop or something and there'll be a cow, like, right in front of me it's like what?

Participant

Laughs

EP

Have you heard of John Constable before the walk? Have you heard the artist before the walk today?

Participant

About this place?

EP

About constable.

Participant

No, no.

I actually asked one lady what is Constable? because in India Constable means police officer. So I thought. Like I googled and saw it was showing Constable like Park or something so I asked whether it's the place? No. [laughs]

EP

[laughs] Yeah, there's definitely police constables, luckily today is less intense but yeah. This field is very beautiful.

Where else have you been in the UK so far? So you went to Cambridge

Participant

This is the only place, yeah London and Cambridge

EP

London how did you find London?

Participant

London is good. Yeah, much like our Mumbai.

EP

It's a lot busier and a lot more intense [than Suffolk]. Do you prefer like the quieter part, or do you prefer like the louder?

Participant

Both are fine for living a peaceful life. Quieter is better. People, What will you do with people, I mean a lot of people. They will be going around doing their work, no? Yeah, once in a while is fine. Because, being brought up in cities it's lots of People, people. People. So this time it's peaceful, at least for sometime

EP

How is your husband finding his role at BT?

Participant

Good. Work/life balance is better because In India, we have to go to work right so he will be coming late. And there will be traffic going to office and coming from office, it's a big task. Like we will stay in one part of the city and the office is at the other end of the city. So the traffic is like one and half hours minimum by two wheeler, or four wheeler, or bus so this is like peaceful less traffic

EP

Yeah we always complain about the traffic in Ipswich. So I guess we should be grateful that it's not that bad.

Next clip

JM

Sort of up in the east part of sort of Kenya and Tanzania they used to sell these T-shirts with mzungu on the front which basically was like

Participant

It's Murungu in Zimbabwe

JM

Murungu in Zimbabwe is it?

Participant

Yeah

JM

A slang for like white person basically. And all the the silly things they do basically

AC

That's great. I find that fascinating

JM

That's Spanish call gringos, isn't it? They call the Brits going over there, you know?, so we used to, we all used to walk around with these stupid T. Shirts on and the children oi mzungu mzungu

AC

We should name a blog post that

JM

I've still got my mzungu t shirts actually, they're in my wardrobe at home they don't fit me anymore.